

The Applicant

written by

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1

INT. CAR - DAY

1

TAYLOR REACH (18), on his way home from school, pulls into his driveway.

He sits for a moment, letting the music play.

On the passenger seat: his dance bag and a brownish folder beside it. The folder is marked:

IN MOTION - International Contemporary Dance Intensive - Rotterdam, Netherlands.

Taylor taps the steering wheel, mimicking the music's beat, then finally shuts the car off.

The music cuts.

He grabs the bag and the folder and heads inside.

CUT TO:

2

INT. TAYLOR'S LIVING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

2

Taylor's mother, MICHELLE REACH, is in the kitchen on a phone call, sorting mail.

MICHELLE
(on the phone)
No, I saw it. I just haven't had a
chance yet—

Taylor enters.

TAYLOR
Hey.

Michelle raises a finger without looking.

MICHELLE
One sec.

Taylor gives a half-laugh, half-sigh and nods to himself, before heading up the stairs toward his room.

Michelle turns away as she continues her call.

MICHELLE (CONT'D)
Sorry—go ahead.

CUT TO:

3 INT. TAYLOR'S BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS

3

Taylor enters.

The room is clearly a dancer's space. A DANCE MAT takes up most of the floor. Medals hang from a hook and old costumes spill over the back of a chair. Taylor's bed lines one wall across from a cluttered DESK. The back of the room is lit by a small WINDOW.

Taylor sets his dance bag down. At the same time, he pulls the brown folder and his phone from the bag, and places them on the desk.

He opens the folder and pulls out the application page.

TAYLOR
(aloud, reading)
In no longer than sixty seconds,
please introduce yourself to the In
Motion team and describe what dance
means to you.

He stares at the page a moment.

TAYLOR (CONT'D)
(to himself, mocking)
Describe what dance means to you.

He exhales and drops the page back on the desk.

Taylor sets up a CAMERA on a TRIPOD near the edge of the dance mat, positioning it so both he and the window behind him are visible in frame. He checks the screen, adjusts the angle slightly, then presses RECORD.

A red light on the camera flickers on.

TAYLOR (CONT'D)
My name is Taylor Reach and I'm
applying to In Motion because—

He stalls, but tries again.

TAYLOR (CONT'D)
Hi. My name is Taylor Reach. I'm
from Stamford, Connecticut and I'm
applying to In Motion because I—

A LAWNMOWER roars outside.

Taylor freezes.

He slowly puts his head in his hands.

He exhales sharply, stands, and walks over to the window.
He opens it.

TAYLOR (CONT'D)
(shouting out the window)
Hey!

The mower cuts out for a second.

NEIGHBOR (O.S.)
Yeah?

TAYLOR
How long you think you're gonna be?

NEIGHBOR (O.S.)
Couple minutes!

TAYLOR
Yeah? How long's "a couple
minutes"?

NEIGHBOR (O.S.)
I don't know. I won't be long kid.
Quit whining!

The mower starts again immediately.

Taylor just stares out the window.

TAYLOR
Unbelievable.

He shuts the window harder than necessary.

Then grabs his phone off the desk.

FADE TO BLACK.

SUPER: 15 MINUTES LATER

4 INT. TAYLOR'S BEDROOM - LATER

4

Taylor sits on the edge of his bed, phone in hand. He opens his contacts and taps his friend RYAN MURPHY'S name.

The FACETIME call connects. On Taylor's screen, Ryan's camera points straight up at a BATHROOM CEILING. The sound of a shower running.

RYAN (O.S.)
Yeah?

TAYLOR
Why am I looking at your ceiling?

RYAN (O.S.)
Because I'm in the shower.

Taylor rubs his forehead.

TAYLOR
Ugh! I'm trying to finish this
application thing and the guy next
door just started mowing his lawn.

RYAN (O.S.)
For that film thing?

TAYLOR
Dance thing. But yeah. I have to
finish it tonight.

RYAN (O.S.)
Where was it again—Sweden?

TAYLOR
The Netherlands. In Rotterdam.

RYAN (O.S.)
Right. Same vibe, I think.

Taylor leans back on the bed.

TAYLOR
I just need sixty seconds, *and*
somehow the perfect answer to an
impossible question.

RYAN (O.S.)
You're overthinking it.

The businessman in me says you
gotta just go in confident. You
know—sell yourself.

Taylor stares at the ceiling.

TAYLOR
Right.

Water continues running on Ryan's end.

RYAN (O.S.)
You coming out later?

TAYLOR
No! I told you I'm finishing this
tonight.

RYAN (O.S.)
Okay, okay. Fair.

Alright I gotta finish getting
ready.

TAYLOR
Of course you do.

The call ends.

Taylor puts his phone down on the bed.

Outside, the LAWNMOWER finally stops.

He looks toward the camera setup again.

CUT TO:

5 INT. TAYLOR'S BEDROOM - LATE AFTERNOON

5

Taylor sits in front of the camera again - more confident
this time.

TAYLOR
Hi. My name is Taylor Reach, and
I'm applying to In Motion because
training abroad would challenge me
as both a performer and
collaborator—

CUT TO:

Taylor watching the recording back.

TAYLOR (ON VIDEO) (CONT'D)
—and I believe working with
international artists will expand
my creative perspective—

Taylor cringes.

TAYLOR (ON VIDEO) (CONT'D)
—while allowing me to contribute my
own background and experience—

He winces again and reaches forward.

The playback STOPS.

6

INT. TAYLOR'S BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS

6

Silence.

He rubs his face.

TAYLOR
Jesus Christ. It sounds like AI.

He rewinds the footage.

The overly confident version of himself continues speaking. He watches for a second longer before quickly shutting it off again.

Then Taylor's frustration starts building.

He becomes restless. He starts pacing the room, running both hands through his hair as the thoughts come out faster than he can organize them.

TAYLOR (CONT'D)
What does that even mean.

He snatches the application page from the desk again.

TAYLOR (CONT'D)
"What does dance mean to you." How
am I supposed to answer that?

He tosses the paper aside and keeps pacing, kicking a pile of clothes out of the way without thinking.

MICHELLE (O.S.)
Taylor?

Taylor ignores her and continues pacing, muttering more to himself now.

TAYLOR
Every time I say it I sound like an
idiot.

MICHELLE (O.S.)
Taylor.

The door opens and Michelle steps in.

MICHELLE (CONT'D)
Can you keep it down a little? I'm
still on the phone.

TAYLOR
Okay.

MICHELLE
I can hear you downstairs.

Taylor laughs once, exhausted.

MICHELLE (CONT'D)
What's going on?

TAYLOR
Nothing.

MICHELLE
Doesn't sound like nothing.

TAYLOR
I'm working on it.

Michelle notices the camera setup.

MICHELLE
Is this that program thing?

TAYLOR
Yeah.

MICHELLE
Then why are you destroying your
room? Just record it.

That lands wrong.

TAYLOR
I'm trying.

MICHELLE
It doesn't have to be perfect.

TAYLOR
It's not about perfect.

MICHELLE
You're overthinking it.

Taylor struggles to explain.

TAYLOR
(at maximum irritation)
I don't know how to explain it!
Just please leave.

MICHELLE
Taylor—

TAYLOR

Please!

MICHELLE

You're making this way harder than
it needs to be.

Taylor grabs the application packet and throws it.

It hits the TRIPOD.

The CAMERA crashes to the floor.

CRACK.

The image jolts violently.

7 INT. TAYLOR'S BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS

7

Taylor rushes over and picks it up. The lens is fractured.

MICHELLE

Oh my—

TAYLOR

Just go.

MICHELLE

Let me see—

TAYLOR

Please just go.

Michelle leaves. The door shuts behind her.

Taylor stands there for a moment holding the broken camera
before setting it crookedly back on the desk.

As it settles, the RECORD BUTTON gets pressed against the
desk edge.

The red RECORD LIGHT flickers on — unnoticed by Taylor.

He starts pacing again, faster now, hands in his hair,
muttering the question over and over like it's mocking him.

TAYLOR (CONT'D)

What does dance mean to you.

He laughs again, frustrated.

TAYLOR (CONT'D)

Yeah. Great question.

He kicks a shoe across the room and knocks a pile of clothes aside while pacing.

TAYLOR (CONT'D)
How do you explain that.

He stops in the middle of the room, breathing hard.

Across the room sits his speaker. He looks at it – remembering the music from earlier in the car.

Taylor walks over and turns it on.

The same bass-heavy instrumental from earlier fills the room.

At first he just moves restlessly with the rhythm, still pacing, still trying to shake off the frustration. But the beat starts to take over.

His pacing turns into movement. The movement turns into dance.

Taylor unfolds into it – contemporary movement with hip-hop influence, using the full space of the room.

The dancing grows larger and more physical, more raw, until he has pushed himself completely out of energy.

Taylor finally drops onto the bed.

He sits there for a moment, then slowly looks toward the camera.

The music fades.

CUT TO BLACK.